

A New England shortline that you can model, Pt.II: The Claremont & Concord Rwy.

With its little red GE diesels, the C&C was a classic Pinsly operation/**Scott Whitney**



SCOTT WHITNEY: CLAREMONT, NH; NOV., 1980

The C&C's 44-tonner No. 31 has just crossed the Sugar River and is turning from Main onto Union St. Behind the engine is the for-

mer Presto Grain Co., which has since been converted into housing for the elderly. To the right is the spur that served River St.

If someone mentions the Boston & Maine of the late steam era your mind immediately conjures up images of ancient Moguls trundling down a cinder ballasted right of way and rolling through wooden covered bridges. And so it was with the Claremont branch of the B&M right up until the mid 1950's. The Claremont branch was certainly neither the last B&M line to host steam nor was it the first B&M line to be sold off as a shortline, however, it was the best known of them all. Much has already been written about the line including an excellent book by Edgar T. Mead titled *Through Covered Bridges To Concord* (long out of print).

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During the mid part of the century, the Boston & Maine decided that the Claremont branch was not a going concern and seriously worked toward the idea of giving up the operation. It was also about this time that shortline entrepreneur Samuel Pinsly was starting his large collection of shortlines. Mr. Pinsly would eventually go on to own and operate six different former B&M or B&M owned operations; the Claremont Branch was among these.

Pinsly had already bought the little Claremont Railway and actively pursued the B&M's Claremont branch which would allow the two to be combined into one efficient operation. On December 17, 1954, the Claremont &

Concord Railway became official. Included in the deal were the buildings, land and some equipment, which included one locomotive and a gas electric passenger set.

Unfortunately, it was to be a shotgun wedding for the poor Claremont Railway. Within an incredibly short time period the wire came down from over the little electric road and most all of the equipment was dissected for the various metals and scrapped. It was decided to utilize the former B&M enginehouse at Claremont Junction rather than the Claremont Railway's car barn for locomotive storage and repair. Soon enough the operation settled into a regular routine.

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